

Kentucky; Clayton-Clarksville, Georgia; Hot Springs-Lake Ouachita, Arkansas; Grand Lake-Lake Tenkiller, Oklahoma; and Fayetteville, Arkansas. The Rand McNally book also says very good things about parts of Maine, New Mexico, and Washington. But most of the best places are in southern or bordering states. You can buy houses there for \$40,000 or rent them for \$250 a month. You can largely forget about air conditioning in summer or heat in winter. The crime and tax rates are a fraction of what you're used to. The cost of living is as low as any place in the U.S. And the best places are a few hours by car from major urban areas like Charlotte, Louisville, and Atlanta.

Peter A. Dickinson reviews retirement areas in *Sunbelt Retirement* (Dutton, 1980). The book speaks to those who want good weather without the high cost of Boca Raton or Scottsdale. Dickinson says a retired couple can live on \$10,000 a year, including \$3,390 for housing, in the places he reviews.

Rather than take the word of these authors, Vicki and I decided to check out the Southeast for ourselves. In June 1986, we flew from Los Angeles to New Orleans and, on a Greyhound bus, worked our way east and north to Washington, D.C. We went to Mobile, Montgomery, and a small town on Perdido Bay in Alabama; to Pensacola and Jacksonville in Florida; to Savannah, Georgia; to Charleston and Columbia in South Carolina; and to Raleigh, North Carolina. In between we saw hundreds of small towns. We stopped to talk to realtors, merchants, bankers, and cabdrivers.

Except in the large urban and resort areas, we found a healthy, easygoing way of life. The air was clean, the sidewalks swept. We met friendly people who want to keep drugs out of their schools, bureaucrats out of their lives, and high-handedness out of their businesses. The nearby big cities, with their international airports, provide plenty of bustle. But with cable TV, home computers, telephone data bases, and a full mailbox, one feels in touch with the larger scheme of things even in very remote places.